

Title: Silent Software Installation Using GPO (Batch Script Method)

Objective: Deploy .exe applications silently to Windows 10 domain-joined computers using Group Policy with startup scripts.

1. Environment Setup

- **Domain Controller (DC1):** Windows Server with Active Directory, DNS, and file sharing configured
 - **Client VMs:** Domain-joined Windows 10 VMs
 - **Applications Deployed:** Firefox, iTunes, (Winamp attempted but unsuccessful)
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2. Shared Software Folder Setup

1. Create a folder on your DC:
 - C:\Shared\Software
 2. Create subfolders for each app (e.g. Firefox, iTunes, Winamp).
 3. **Set Share and NTFS Permissions:**
 - Right-click the Software folder → Properties → Sharing → Advanced Sharing → Share this folder
 - Permissions: Add Domain Computers and grant Read permission
 - Also set NTFS Security tab permissions: Add Domain Computers → Read & Execute, List folder contents, Read
- ✅ This is crucial when deploying to computers via Startup scripts. Domain Computers must have read access.
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3. Script Creation

Each script logs activity and attempts to silently install the target .exe.

Example: Firefox (Works)

```
@echo off
set LOGFILE=C:\install_log_firefox.txt
set INSTALLER="\\DC1\Software\Firefox\Firefox_Setup_141.exe"

echo [%date% %time%] Starting Firefox install > %LOGFILE%

if exist %INSTALLER% (
    echo [%date% %time%] Installer found, launching... >> %LOGFILE%
    %INSTALLER% /S >> %LOGFILE% 2>&1
)
```

```

    echo [%date% %time%] Exit Code: %ERRORLEVEL% >> %LOGFILE%
    if %errorlevel% equ 0 (
        echo [%date% %time%] Firefox installed successfully >> %LOGFILE%
    ) else (
        echo [%date% %time%] Firefox install FAILED with exit code
%errorlevel% >> %LOGFILE%
    )
) else (
    echo [%date% %time%] Installer not found >> %LOGFILE%
)

```

Example: iTunes (Works)

```

@echo off
set LOGFILE=C:\install_log_itunes.txt
set INSTALLER="\\DC1\Software\iTunes\iTunesSetup.exe"

echo [%date% %time%] Starting iTunes install > %LOGFILE%

if exist %INSTALLER% (
    echo [%date% %time%] Installer found, launching... >> %LOGFILE%
    %INSTALLER% /quiet >> %LOGFILE% 2>&1

    echo [%date% %time%] Exit Code: %ERRORLEVEL% >> %LOGFILE%
    if %errorlevel% equ 0 (
        echo [%date% %time%] iTunes installed successfully >> %LOGFILE%
    ) else (
        echo [%date% %time%] iTunes install FAILED with exit code
%errorlevel% >> %LOGFILE%
    )
) else (
    echo [%date% %time%] Installer not found >> %LOGFILE%
)

```

Example: Winamp (Failed - Not Fully Silent)

- Downloaded from official site
- Appears to support /S, but still prompts GUI even after VS2019 runtime was installed
- Silent install fails due to hidden user interaction dependencies

4. Group Policy Configuration

1. Open **Group Policy Management**
2. Create or edit a GPO linked to the OU containing your computers
3. Navigate to:
 - Computer Configuration > Policies > Windows Settings > Scripts (Startup/Shutdown)

4. Add your .cmd or .bat file under **Startup**
 5. Place the script file in \\DC1\NETLOGON or \\DC1\Shared\Scripts and reference it
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5. Troubleshooting Tips

- Always test the .exe /S or /quiet switches manually first
 - Use full UNC path (e.g. \\DC1\Software\Firefox\Firefox_Setup_141.exe)
 - Log outputs to C:\install_log_*.txt for debug
 - Use tools like **Process Explorer** or **Event Viewer** if things don't install
 - Consider using .msi for easier management when available
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6. Conclusion

You can reliably deploy silent installers using GPO startup scripts for .exe applications—**as long as the `\*\* truly supports silent install flags.\*\*** Applications like Firefox and iTunes work well; others like Winamp may not support full silent installs even if they accept/S`.

You've successfully implemented:

- Shared folder access via Domain Computers
 - Batch scripting with error logging
 - GPO deployment targeting computers
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Next Step

Explore .msi deployment via GPO or move toward using **SCCM** or **Intune** for enterprise-grade software distribution.